

Tribal India — Religion, Nation State, Approaches, PVTGs, DNTs & NGOs

UPSC Anthropology Optional | Paper 2 — Units 7.1, 8.1, 8.2, 9.1, 9.2, 9.3 | Source: Sarrthi IAS
Handout 6, L-67 (Nataraj Sir)

Syllabus Covered:

- **8.1** — Impact of Hinduism, Buddhism, Christianity, Islam on tribal societies
- **8.2** — Tribe and Nation State
- **9.1** — History of administration of tribal areas; Particularly Vulnerable Tribal Groups (PVTGs)
- **7.1** — Denotified Tribes (DNTs)
- **9.1** — Role of NGOs in tribal development
- **9.2** — Role of Anthropology in tribal and rural development
- **9.3** — Communalism

8.1 — Impact of Hinduism on Tribal Societies

Key Statistics:

- More than **90%** of tribal population directed towards Hinduism
- **95%** among total tribal population are Hinduised

Historical Background & Entry of Hinduism

- During British rule, cultural contact between tribal societies and urban areas was rapid
- Significant increase in cultural contact through "**Peasantization**" (N.K. Bose)
- Hinduism is **smooth and more compatible** — tribes can continue with original values and also adopt new ones
- **Hinduised tribal groups:** Bhils, Bhumij, Gonds
- Forms of gotras are more **totemistic than Vedic** → basis of the **Tribe-Caste Continuum**

Tribe-Rajput Continuum (N.K. Bose): Bhumij tribes studied → tribes follow the **Rajput Model**. Tribes like **Tharu** and **Khasa** got themselves accepted as Kshatriya. Process called "**Kshatriyaization**" — a popular form of Sanskritization. Hinduism created a Tribe-Caste Continuum that allowed partial absorption without full erasure of identity.

Case Study — Bhil Tribe: Bhils practiced theft and dacoity. They believe Goddess Parvati was a Bhil; when they demanded bride price from Shiva, he refused. They killed Nandi (Shiva's bullock), were cursed to poverty but given a Vardaan: theft for livelihood invites no sin. Some sub-tribes consider themselves "*thieves of Mahadev*" — a mythological legitimization of their economic practices.

Positive Impacts of Hinduism

Impact	Details
Cultural Integration & Social Mobility	Through Sanskritisation (Srinivas, 1952), Gonds, Bhils, Oraons adopted Hindu customs to claim higher status
Incorporation into Civilizational Ethos	Tribal deities absorbed into Hindu pantheon — Gond deity Pharsa Pen → Shiva; Santhal Marang Buru → Mahadeo
Spread of Agriculture & Settled Life	Peasantization (N.K. Bose) — Bhumij, Bhils, Oraons moved from jhum to settled agriculture
Introduction of Literacy	Raj Gonds used Sanskrit titles (Raja/Thakur) to legitimize political authority
Religious Tolerance	Polytheistic worldview allowed coexistence — Navakhani (Oraons) and Holi (Bhils) celebrated jointly

Negative Impacts of Hinduism

Impact	Details
Replacement of Simple Rituals	Lambadi (Banjara) now employ Brahmin priests for life-cycle rituals — economic dependence on outsiders
Decline of Traditional Institutions	Youth dormitories — Ghotul (Muria Gonds) and Dhumkuria (Oraons) — declined under Hindu moral codes
Emergence of Dowry	Bride price → dowry among Ho, Munda, Gond — reversed egalitarian gender norms

Child Marriage & Widow Restrictions	Bhil and Gond tribes: child marriage encouraged, widow remarriage prohibited
Caste-like Hierarchies	Raj Gonds developed internal stratification resembling caste; similar among Oraons and Bhils
Loss of Cultural Autonomy	Tribal deities subordinated as local Hindu manifestations; tribal myths reinterpreted through Hindu cosmological lens

Conclusion: *Hinduism has had a significant influence leading to **Tribe-Caste Continuum**. Interaction resulted in assimilation of novel customs and practices. The process was gradual, often voluntary, and allowed tribes to negotiate their position within the caste hierarchy while maintaining partial cultural distinctiveness.*

UPSC PYQ / Probable Q: "Critically examine the impact of Hinduism on tribal societies with reference to the Tribe-Caste Continuum." | "Discuss Sanskritization as a process of social mobility among tribal groups." | "How has Hindu religious contact transformed tribal social institutions like bride price, youth dormitories, and kinship?"

8.1 — Impact of Christianity on Tribal Societies

Overview:

- Spread of Christianity began during the **colonial period**
- Christianity is the **second largest religion among tribal communities**, next only to Hinduism
- **Northeastern region** has the highest concentration of Christian tribal populations

Positive Impacts of Christianity

1. First Organized Agency for Tribal Welfare

Before state schemes, missionaries were the first organized agency — brought literacy, healthcare, and social awareness to remote forest areas.

2. Introduction of Education and Tribal Scripts

- **Mizoram:** Rev. J. H. Lorrain and F. W. Savidge (1894) — established schools, books in Mizo language

- **Nagaland:** American Baptist Mission — first village school at Molungyimsen (1872)
- **Jharkhand/Chhattisgarh:** Rev. John Baptist Hoffmann (Munda grammar), Paul Olaf Bodding (Santal dictionary)
- **Arunachal Pradesh:** Among Adi and Nyishi, mission schools were first sources of literacy

3. Westernization — Elimination of Harmful Practices

- **Nagaland:** Headhunting and fertility rituals disappeared
- If mother died during childbirth, baby was buried with her → missionaries established orphanages and infant homes
- Improved health through dispensaries, hospitals, vaccination, maternal care

4. Prohibition of Alcohol

Young Mizo Association (YMA) campaigns against rice beer (Zu) — reduced alcoholism and family disputes.

5. Syncretism and Religious Coexistence

Jharkhand: Christian Santals and Oraons celebrate Karma and Sohrai festivals with drums and hymns — described as "*religious layering*" — new beliefs added without erasing old ones.

Negative Impacts of Christianity

1. Ethnocentric Approach

Missionaries saw tribal faiths as "primitive" → erosion of customs, songs, and institutions. Cultural arrogance embedded in proselytization.

2. Sense of Superiority Among Converts

Christian Oraons of Chotanagpur developed feeling of superiority over non-Christians → fractured tribal unity.

3. Massive Demographic Change

- **Arunachal Pradesh:** Conversion among Wancho, Nocte, Tangsa, Nyishi rose from <5% (1970s) to ~80% (2011)
- **Nagaland:** ~90% of Nagas (Ao, Angami, Lotha, Sema) became Christian via Miles Bronson and E.W. Clark's missions
- **Mizoram:** Mizo population converted almost entirely by early 20th century

4. Loss of Traditional Institutions

Morung (Nagas) and Ghotul (Gonds) declined — disrupted transmission of folklore and moral instruction. Mundas and Oraons stopped celebrating Karma and Sarhul.

5. Political Identity Implications

- **IFCSAP (Arunachal Pradesh):** Demands delisting of converted Christians from ST benefits
- **Nagaland/Mizoram:** Christianity became base for ethnic nationalism
- **Jaipal Singh Munda:** Blended Christian and tribal ideals to mobilize Adivasi political movements

Revivalist Movements in Response to Christian Influence

- **Donyi-Polo movement (Arunachal Pradesh):** Institutionalized Sun-Moon worship through temples (Khumkos) and schools
- **Sarna Dharma revival (Central India):** Reaffirmed nature worship (Singbonga) among Munda and Oraon; All India Sarna Samiti demands separate Census code
- **Gond Mahasabha:** Promotes Koya Punem, worshipping Baradeo as supreme god

Conclusion: Christianity played a transformative yet complex role — education, literacy, healthcare, social reforms on one side; cultural loss and religious polarization on the other. The Christian mission was simultaneously liberatory and colonial.

UPSC Probable Q: "Assess the role of Christian missionaries in tribal development with specific examples from Northeast India." | "How did Christianity contribute to both the advancement and fragmentation of tribal identity?" | "Discuss revivalist movements among tribes as a response to Christianization."

8.1 — Impact of Buddhism on Tribal Societies

Overview:

- Buddhism followed by around **0.5%** of Indian tribal population
- Spread linked to **Mauryan and Kushan emperors**; Ashoka played a key role
- Buddhism is a **way of life** — tribes could follow it alongside their own beliefs
- Impact primarily in **North-west and North-east Himalayan regions**

Key Tribal Groups Influenced by Buddhism

- **Bhutias** (Sikkim)
- **Lepchas** (Meghalaya, Arunachal Pradesh, Bhutan, Sikkim, Darjeeling)
- **Chakmas** (Mizoram, Arunachal Pradesh)
- **Monpa, Sherdukpen, Khowa** (Arunachal Pradesh)
- **Brokpa, Changpa, Balti** (Ladakh)

C. von Furer-Haimendorf (1983): Buddhist converts in Arunachal Pradesh did not renounce tribal rituals. This symbiotic relationship between Buddhism and tribal religion is the key feature distinguishing Buddhist tribal conversion from Christian conversion. Monasteries like **Bapuchang** in Khampti and Singpho villages established; sacred specialists are **Lamas**. *Sherdukpen* worship tribal deities alongside Lamas; *Monpas* have elements of ancient **Bon religion** coexisting with Buddhism.

Case Studies: Buddhism and Tribes

Tribe	Region	Key Finding
Bhutia	Sikkim, Darjeeling	Follow Vajrayana Buddhism (17th–18th c.); Losoong (Sikkimese New Year) and animistic dances coexist → cultural continuity within conversion
Lepcha	Sikkim, NE Himalayas	Bon-like healing rituals and ancestor worship alongside Buddhist ceremonies — syncretism
Chakma	Arunachal, Mizoram	Theravada Buddhists; still worship Lakshmi and forest spirits; village councils blend Buddhist codes with customary law — accommodation, not replacement
Monpa/Sherdukpen/Khowa	Arunachal Pradesh	Mahayana Buddhism; Sherdukpen worship tribal deities alongside Lamas; Bon elements among Monpas — symbiotic coexistence
Brokpa/Changpa/Balti	Ladakh	Mahayana dominant; pre-Buddhist mountain-spirit worship (Lha/Yul-lha), animal-sacrifice rituals continue — religious coexistence

Conclusion: Buddhism integrated with indigenous cosmologies **rather than replacing them**. Non-dogmatic nature, emphasis on ethics over exclusivity, acceptance of local gods as Dharma protectors → **syncretic evolution**. Even the adoption of Buddhism could not cut through traditional beliefs. Limited but significant impact.

UPSC Probable Q: "Compare and contrast the impact of Buddhism and Christianity on tribal societies in India." | "Why did Buddhism lead to syncretic integration while Christianity often led to cultural rupture?" | "Discuss C. von Furer-Haimendorf's observations on Buddhism and tribal identity."

8.1 — Impact of Islam on Tribal Societies

Overview:

- Islam's penetration faced challenges due to **dogmatic nature** and limited support from Muslim rulers
- Dissemination fell largely upon **Sufi saints and preachers**

Muslim Tribal Groups in India

- **Siddis** of Gujarat
- **Gujjars** of North-western Himalayas
- **Bakarwals** of Jammu and Kashmir
- **Bhils, Kotis, Dhankasi** of Rajasthan
- **Entire population of Lakshadweep** — seven Muslim tribal communities: Koya, Malmi, Malacheri, Manikfan, Thakrufan, Thakru, and Reveri

Key Tribal Group Profiles:

Group	Region	Islamic Identity + Tribal Retention
Bakarwal & Gujjar Bakarwal	J&K, Ladakh	Nomadic, Sunni Muslim, ST since 1991; transhumance intact; Gujar language retained
Siddi	Gujarat, Karnataka, Goa	African origin; Muslim but retain African music/dance (Goma/Dhamaal) — Islam overlaid on older cultural base
Lakshadweep Islanders	Lakshadweep	Sunni Muslim but still matrilineal, still have Taravad, still practise duolocal residence
Van Gujjars	NW Himalaya	Pastoral, Sunni Muslim; marriage and seasonal movement follow traditional pastoral rules

General Impacts of Islam

Impact	Details
Shift to Patrilineal Norms	Transition from matrilineal/bilateral to patrilineal under Sharia inheritance norms
Islamisation of Life Cycle Rituals	Progressive replacement of traditional birth/marriage/death ceremonies
Observance of Islamic Festivals	Prophet Mohammed's birthday adopted; indigenous festivals declined
Decline of Indigenous Practices	Folk dances and indigenous practices declined sharply
Replacement of Tribal Social Order	Islamic personal laws replaced traditional social mechanisms

Preference for Cousin Marriages

Became preferential among converted tribes, altering kinship patterns

Detailed Case Study — Islam and Matriliney in Lakshadweep

The Taravad (Matrilineal Unit) — Structure:

- Group of individuals tracing descent through common genealogy from an **ancestress** in unbroken female line
- Depth: **3 to 6 or more generations**
- Every Taravad has a **name** used as prefix to personal names
- Birth in Taravad gives right to share in **Taravad property** (land, trees, boats, buildings) — passes through female members
- Male members have only **usufructuary rights** (use but not ownership)
- Taravad is a **matrilineal exogamous unit**
- Father has **no legal responsibility** for children's maintenance — children belong to mother's descent group
- Background: Matriliney brought by nearest coastal people of **Kerala**

Islam's Influence on Matriliney — The Tension:

- Islamic marriage procedure adopted BUT **duolocal residence pattern not given up**
- **Duolocal residential arrangement:** Men and women including spouses live in *separate houses*
- Most religious activities (festivals, Quran chanting, fulfilment of vows) carried out **within the context of the matrilineal group**
- If Taravad has an ancestor-saint, anniversary celebrated by entire matrilineage
- Islam provides easy divorce → **high frequency of divorce** in Lakshadweep
- **Current Changes (Islamisation):** Matrilineal practices gradually eroding — growing shift toward **patriliney, nuclear family residence, and male headship**

Three-Point Summary of Negative Impacts:

1. **Erosion of Traditional Kinship:** Shift from matrilineal/bilateral to patrilineal under Sharia inheritance — Lakshadweep Taravad weakened
2. **Decline of Indigenous Rituals:** Ancestor worship, spirit appeasement, sacred dances replaced by namaz, fasting, Islamic festivals

3. **Dual Marginalisation:** Gujjars and Bakarwals perceived as socially inferior to Ashraf Muslims (Syeds, Pathans) — outside both Islamic upper layers and mainstream economy

Conclusion: Islam influenced tribal societies through new religious practices, laws, and social norms. Yet tribes like those in Lakshadweep **adapted Islam within their own cultural frameworks**, creating a blend of faith and indigenous identity. Islam's more dogmatic character meant deeper cultural disruption than Buddhism, yet Sufi influence allowed some syncretic adaptation.

UPSC Probable Q: "Explain the concept of Taravad in Lakshadweep and how Islam has impacted the matrilineal system there." | "Compare the impact of Islam and Buddhism on tribal social structures." | "How have tribal groups in India adapted world religions within their own cultural frameworks?"

8.2 — Tribe and Nation State

Key Definitions

Concept	Definition
Tribe	Social group with territorial affiliation, endogamous, no specialization of functions, ruled by hereditary/tribal officers, united in language/dialect
Nation	Community based on shared language, history, ethnicity, culture, society — collective identity of a group
State	Centralized political organization imposing rules over a population within a territory; maintains monopoly on legitimate use of violence (Max Weber)
Nation State	Political unit where state and nation are congruent ; people share common identity, culture, history

Nation vs. Nation State — Examples:

- **Kurds** = nation *without* a state
- **France, Germany, Japan** = classic nation-states
- **Korea** = one nation divided into two states (North and South)

Who are Indigenous and Tribal Peoples?

More than **370 million people** in more than **70 countries** worldwide. No universal definition — ILO Convention No. 169 takes a practical approach.

ILO Convention No. 169 — Criteria

Category	Subjective Criteria	Objective Criteria
Indigenous peoples	Self-identification	Descent from populations present at time of conquest/colonization; retain own social, economic, cultural, political institutions
Tribal peoples	Self-identification	Social, cultural, economic conditions distinguish them from national community; status regulated by customs, traditions, or special laws

India's Special Case: Division into indigenous vs settlers is **NOT valid** in India — India cannot be divided into "natives" and "non-natives." Other terms used globally: native peoples, aboriginal peoples, first nations, adivasi, janajati, hunter-gatherers, hill tribes. In **Latin America**, "tribal" is applied to some afro-descendent communities.

Challenges of Tribes vis-à-vis Nation States

1. **Tribal identity & culture:** Distinct cultures, languages, traditions → conflicts over land rights and cultural preservation when nation-state imposes uniformity
2. **Self-governance & self-determination:** Tribal structures clash with centralized authority; self-determination is a fundamental human right under international law
3. **Colonization & forced assimilation:** History of resentment and mistrust; nation-state must acknowledge historical injustices to build trust

UPSC Probable Q: "How do tribal identities come into conflict with the nation-state's demand for uniform citizenship?" | "Examine ILO Convention 169's definition of tribal and indigenous peoples and its relevance to India." | "Critically examine the challenges faced by tribal communities in relation to national integration."

Various Approaches Towards Tribal Development

Approach	Key Thinker	Philosophy / Metaphor	Criticism
Isolationist "Keep them"	Verrier Elwin, 'The Baiga', 1939	Tribes left alone, minimum outside contact. "National	Accused of keeping tribes as "labs" for field studies;

apart"		Park Theory" — huge tract of land for tribes to live in isolation. Image: <i>Two separate bowls</i>	suspected of keeping them underdeveloped; tribes should contribute to India's progress
Assimilationist "Melting Pot"	G.S. Ghurye — tribes are "backward Hindus"	Tribes absorbed into mainstream; lose customs, language, traditions; tribes would "catch up" by mingling with rest of society. Image: <i>Melting pot</i>	Ethnocentric; forced assimilation is unfair; destroys cultural heritage; ignores the value of tribal knowledge systems
Integrationist ✓ (India's approach) "Salad Bowl"	Post-independent Verrier Elwin, 'A Philosophy for NEFA', 1957 (foreword by Nehru)	Integrating tribes into mainstream while they retain their identity . Choice of how, when, and to what extent to integrate — left to tribals themselves. Image: <i>Salad bowl — each ingredient keeps its flavour</i>	Implementation gaps; tribes often pressured; development still disrupts culture

Comparative Global Examples:

- **Isolationist — USA:** Indian reservation system → life was difficult; poverty, malnutrition, low standards of living. In 1868, President Ulysses S. Grant tried assimilation through Christian clergy → violent resistance → policy abandoned
- **Assimilationist — Australia:** "*Stolen Generations*" (1910–1970): ~100,000 Indigenous children removed from families, placed with white families. **Aboriginal Protection Act of 1869** (Victoria): restricted movement. Policies abolished in 1970s–80s; impacts still felt today

Tribal Panchsheel — Nehru's 5 Principles (1957)

Principle	Explanation
1. Non-imposition	Tribals develop along their own genius; nothing imposed from outside
2. Respect for tribal rights	Rights to land and forests must be respected and protected
3. Development of tribal leadership	Train tribal youth to lead their own administration and development
4. Simplicity of administration	Avoid over-bureaucratisation; schemes should be people-centric and accessible

5. Emphasis on human growth

Evaluate success by quality of life, not mere statistics

UNDRIP 2007 — United Nations Declaration on the Rights of Indigenous Peoples:

- **Against forced assimilation (Article 8):** Right not to be subjected to forced assimilation or destruction of culture
- **For integration (Article 5):** Right to maintain distinct political, legal, economic, social, cultural institutions while retaining right to participate in national life

UNDRIP aligns with India's integrationist approach — integration with identity preserved.

Affirmative Action — USA (Comparative): Policies to address historical discrimination of African Americans, Hispanic Americans, Native Americans, and Women. **Fisher v. University of Texas (2016):** Court upheld race as a factor in admissions; stricter standard requiring no workable race-neutral alternative — shows tension between integration and equity.

UPSC PYQ / Probable Q: "Compare isolationist, assimilationist, and integrationist approaches to tribal development. Which is most suitable for India and why?" | "What is Tribal Panchsheel? How does it reflect Nehru's vision for tribal development?" | "Examine UNDRIP 2007 in the context of India's tribal policy."

9.1 — History of Tribal Administration in India

British Era — Isolationist and Exploitative

Why the British pursued an Isolationist Policy (4 Rationales):

1. **Security & Political Control:** Tribal groups seen as "explosive" — e.g., Santhal Uprising; isolation cut them from national movements
2. **Economic Interests:** Tribal belts rich in forests/minerals; Forest laws to secure timber and land for British revenue and railways
3. **Cultural Justification:** British anthropologists portrayed tribes as "noble savages" needing protection — paternalistic racism
4. **Missionary Access:** Allowed missionaries and select officials; cultural penetration with political dominance

Case Study: The Malers (Paharias) of Rajmahal Hills — First Separate Administrative Model:

- Among first tribes under separate administrative model
- **Cleveland** established ring-fence of sepoy tracts around hill tracts to isolate Paharias
- **1782**: Rajmahal Hill Tract withdrawn from ordinary judicial system; special Hill Assembly with tribal reps + British officers, could impose capital punishment
- Codified as **Regulation I of 1796**, later repealed by **Regulation I of 1827**
- Area known as **Daman-e-Koh** — indirect rule through limited tribal autonomy
- Became prototype for later "special administrative areas"

Major Tribal Uprisings Under British Rule

Uprising	Year
Ho Mutiny of Singhbhum	1831
Khond Uprising	1846
Santhal Rebellion	1855–56
Angami Naga Resistance	1879–80
Abor and Lushai Expeditions	1880–1910

Causes of Uprisings: Loss of land/forest rights (Permanent Settlement, Forest Acts), economic exploitation (zamindars, moneylenders), cultural displacement, political marginalization.

Major Legislative Measures — Timeline

Legislation	Year	Key Provision
Scheduled District Act (Act XIV)	1874	Exempt specified districts from conventional laws; protect from exploitation
Government of India Act — Wholly Excluded Areas	1919	Completely outside British legislation; Governor has legislative authority; neither federal nor provincial legislatures can pass laws
Government of India Act — Partially Excluded Areas	1919	Partially exempted from British legislation; Simon Commission basis

Government of India Act	1935	Continued designation as excluded and partially excluded zones (Simon Commission recommendations)
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Post-Independence Tribal Administration

Key Constitutional Provisions:

- **Article 342:** Defines Scheduled Tribes; President can declare tribes as STs
- **Article 366(25):** ST means tribes deemed under Article 342 of the Constitution
- **Article 244 (Part IV):** President can declare any area as **Scheduled Area** (Fifth Schedule) — substantial tribal population
- **DPSP:** State shall promote with special care educational and economic interests of STs
- **Sixth Schedule:** Administration of northeastern states
- **Fifth Five-Year Plan:** Introduced **Tribal Sub-Plan (TSP)** for integrated development

British Era vs. Post-Independence — Comparison Table

Dimension	British Era	Post-Independence
Approach	Isolation and control	Integrationist and empowerment
Objective	Maintain colonial order, extract resources	Social justice, inclusion, national integration
Laws	Criminal Tribes Act 1871, Scheduled District Act 1874, GoI Act 1935	Constitutional safeguards, PESA 1996, FRA 2006
Administration	Centralised, autocratic, exploitative	Decentralised, participatory (Panchayati Raj)
Outcome	Widespread alienation, land dispossession, uprisings	Uneven progress; persistent challenges in displacement, inequality

9.1 — Particularly Vulnerable Tribal Groups (PVTGs)

What are PVTGs? — Features

General Tribal Features: Primitive traits, distinctive culture, geographical isolation, shyness of contact, backwardness.

Additional Features of PVTGs (over and above general tribal features):

- Dependency on **hunting and gathering** for food
- **Pre-agriculture level of technology**
- **Zero or Negative growth of population**
- Extremely **low level of literacy**

5 Criteria for Identifying PVTGs

1. Forest dependent livelihood
2. Pre-agriculture level of technology
3. Stagnant or declining population
4. Low literacy rate
5. Subsistence-based economy

Historical Development of the PVTG Category

Year	Development
1973	Dhebar Commission created Primitive Tribal Groups (PTGs) as a separate category
1975	Government of India identified 52 groups as PVTGs
1993	Another 23 groups added → total 75 PVTGs out of 705 Scheduled Tribes
2006	Government renamed PTGs as PVTGs (Particularly Vulnerable Tribal Groups)

75 PVTGs spread across 18 States and 1 Union Territory (2011 Census)

Population Data

Key Population Statistics:

- 2001 Census: approximately **27,68,322**
- **12 PVTGs** have population of 50,000; remaining have 1,000 or less
- Huge variation: **Great Andamanese, Onge, Sentinelese** (very few individuals) to **Toda of Nilgiris** (~1,000+)
- **Declining PVTGs:** Onge, Andamanese — biggest reason: *inbreeding*
- **Stagnant:** Birhor in central India
- **Largest PVTG:** *Saharia people of Madhya Pradesh and Rajasthan* — population more than 4 lakhs

Literacy Rate

- Increased from **single digit to 30–40%** in many PVTGs
- Female literacy still considerably lower than male
- **Factors for low literacy:** Linguistic barriers, social exclusion, lack of cultural sensitivity, discrimination, poor infrastructure

Livelihood

- Depend on: **food gathering, NTFP, hunting, livestock rearing, shifting cultivation, artisan works**
- Forests are their life and livelihood

Forest Rights Act (FRA 2006) — Key Provisions for PVTGs:

- **Section 3(1)(e):** Recognizes "rights including community tenures of habitat and habitation for primitive tribal groups and pre-agricultural communities"
- **Section 2(h):** Defines 'habitat' as customary habitat in Reserved and Protected Forests of PTGs and pre-agricultural communities

Challenges to PVTG Livelihood

- Shrinking forests, environmental change, new forest conservation policies
- **2009:** Baiga families moved out of Achanakmar Reserve — loss of livelihood, no proper compensation
- **Kattunayakans (Tamil Nadu):** Prevented from collecting honey in Mudumalai Wildlife Sanctuary — harassment from forest guards
- Exploitation by middlemen — PVTGs unaware of value of their products (honey, tendu leaves)

Health Issues

- Poverty, lack of safe drinking water, bad sanitary conditions, difficult terrain, malnutrition, poor maternal health
- Common diseases: **Anaemia, Malaria, Gastro-intestinal disorders**

Bonded Labour among PVTGs

- **Sahariya (Rajasthan):** Work as bonded labour for rich landlords for generations; tricked into loans with exorbitant interest
- Banned under **Bonded Labour (Abolition) Act 1976**
- **PVTGs in Odisha:** Debt bondage locally called "*goti*" — despite Orissa Debt Bondage (Abolition and Regulation) Act, 1948

PM-JANMAN Scheme (2023) — For PVTGs

Pradhan Mantri Janjati Adivasi Nyaya Maha Abhiyan (PM-JANMAN):

- **Purpose:** Reach the most marginalized and remote PVTGs with saturation of key welfare programmes
- Ministry of Tribal Affairs implements "**Development of Particularly Vulnerable Tribal Groups (PVTGs)**"
- **Conservation-Cum-Development (CCD):** Annual plans prepared by each state/UT based on need assessment, approved by Project Appraisal Committee
- Focus areas: housing, roads, drinking water, education, healthcare, livelihood, mobile medical units

UPSC Probable Q: "What are PVTGs? Discuss the criteria for their identification and the challenges they face." | "Critically evaluate government schemes for PVTGs with reference to PM-JANMAN." | "How does the Forest Rights Act 2006 specifically address the needs of PVTGs?"

7.1 — Denotified Tribes (DNTs)

Historical Background — The Criminal Tribes Act

Criminal Tribes Acts (CTA) — 1871 and 1911:

- **150–200 communities** deemed "Hereditary Criminals" → surveillance, confinement, gross discrimination
- Part of colonial model: communities that **resisted British rule** were targeted
- **Criteria:** Only "reason to believe" needed (not factual evidence) that community was "addicted" to crime
- Notion that **crime was a genetic trait** passed down generations — pseudo-scientific racism

Legal Definition (CTA): "A Criminal Tribe is a gang, tribe or class of people addicted to the systematic commission of Non-Bailable Offenses and with reason to believe, a local Government could notify using the local gazette that an entire tribe, gang or class of people were criminals."

Repeal and Aftermath

- CTA repealed in **1952** on recommendation of **All India Criminal Tribes Inquiry Committee (1949)**
- 'Criminal Tribes' became '**Denotified Tribes**'
- CTA replaced by **Habitual Offenders Act, 1951**
- Communities celebrate **August 31 as Independence Day** (denotification date), but stigma remains

Classification — Scattered Across SC/ST/OBC

Some listed as **Scheduled Tribes**, others as **Scheduled Castes**, some as **OBCs**. **Example of the same community across states:**

- **ST** in Andhra Pradesh, Odisha, Bihar
- **SC** in Karnataka, Delhi, Rajasthan
- **OBC** in Uttar Pradesh
- **Denotified Tribe** in Maharashtra and Tamil Nadu

This inconsistency prevents effective welfare delivery.

Challenges Faced by DNTs

#	Challenge	Details
1	Social Stigma	Labelled "born criminals"; stigma not completely abolished by 1952 Act; police harassment continues
2	Economic Hardship	Traditional occupations (snake charming, street acrobatics, performing with animals) notified as criminal activity
3	Large-scale Exclusions	Spread among SC/ST/OBC but many not classified anywhere; severe lack of data
4	Poor Grievance Redressal	No permanent commission unlike NCSC/NCST
5	Lack of Uniform Approach	Anomalies in identification from state to state — same community classified differently
6	Declining Population	Result of accumulated disadvantages — health, nutrition, marginalisation

Government Schemes for DNTs

#	Scheme	Purpose
1	Dr. Ambedkar Pre-matric and Post-Matric Scholarship	Scholarships for DNT Boys and Girls at school and college level
2	Nanaji Deshmukh Scheme of Construction of Hostels	Hostel facilities for DNT Boys and Girls for educational support
3	Assistance for Skill Development of OBCs/DNTs/EBCs	Vocational and skill training to improve livelihood options

Key Committees on DNTs

Renke Commission / Idade Commission: Compiled data on **809 Nomadic** and **334 Denotified Tribes**. Recommended:

- Establishment of a **Permanent Commission** for DNTs
- Repeal of **Habitual Offenders Act, 1952**
- **Sub-quotas** within SC, ST, OBC categories for DNTs
- **Socio-economic survey** through reputed social science institutes (basic census data missing)
- Centre should carve **sub-categories: DNT-SC, DNT-ST, and DNT-OBC** with dedicated sub-quota

Conclusion: *DNTs continue to face stigma, exclusion, and economic hardship despite repeal of Criminal Tribes Act. True rehabilitation demands de-stigmatisation, accurate identification, targeted welfare measures, a permanent commission, and repeal of the Habitual Offenders Act.*

UPSC Probable Q: "Discuss the historical origins and present-day challenges of Denotified Tribes (DNTs) in India." | "Critically examine the Criminal Tribes Acts and their legacy on marginalized communities." | "What measures have been taken by the government for the rehabilitation of DNTs? Are they sufficient?"

9.1 — Role of NGOs / Voluntary Agencies in Tribal Development

Historical Evolution

- **Ancient times:** Rishis and sannyasins — medicine, spirituality, ethical living
- **British period:** Christian missionaries — education, healthcare, social reform in tribal areas
- **Post-independence:** Secular social organisations and NGOs

Definition of NGO (World Bank): "Private organizations that pursue activities to relieve suffering, promote the interests of the poor, protect the environment, provide basic social services, or undertake community development." Non-profit groups functioning independently of government; also called **civil societies**.

Key Social Workers and Voluntary Institutions

Organisation / Person	Contribution
A.V. Thakkar (Thakkar Bapa)	Established Bhil Seva Mandal in Gujarat; started 21 similar institutions for tribal welfare
Dr. Rajendra Prasad	Founded Bharatiya Adimjati Sevak Sangh — "development of tribal communities with multidimensional view"
Ramakrishna Mission	Promotes welfare at national/state level; emphasis on <i>character building</i> ; free from proselytization
Dhebar Commission	Proposed Forest Labourers Cooperatives in Gujarat and Maharashtra
Sarva Seva Sangh / Gandhi Smarak Nidhi	Emphasized Panchayat raj, prohibition, legal assistance for tribals

M.N. Srinivas observed: Developmental activities by missionaries viewed by Hindus as "bait in the trap of conversion." **Dhebar Commission:** "In many places, the teachings of these missionaries have led to a vertical division of society."

Limitations of NGOs

Limitation	Details
Misuse of Funds	Shilu Ao Committee (1960): highlighted financial irregularities and duplication. NITI Aayog (2020) and CAG audits: gaps in financial accountability
FCRA Non-compliance	Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Act, 2010; between 2011–2023: over 12,000 NGOs (including Oxfam India) lost foreign funding licences. Centre for Social Impact and Philanthropy (2022): criticised cancellations as tools of political control
Perceived Hindrance to Development	Classified 2014 Intelligence Bureau report: International NGOs (Greenpeace, Amnesty, ActionAid) reduced India's GDP by 2–3% annually by opposing mining, infrastructure, nuclear projects — claim lacks empirical verification
Lack of Transparency	CAG report (2018): Less than 10% of registered NGOs submitted annual reports or financial audits. No unified regulatory framework; responsibilities divided among NITI Aayog, Home Ministry (FCRA), State Charity Commissioners

Case Studies on Tribal Welfare Interventions

A. Economic Interventions

Initiative	Location	Details & Impact
Horti-agro forestry for tribal women	Jawadhu Hills, Tamil Nadu	Additional income for single women families; men often migrate or lost to smuggling — women supported through agroforestry
Honey Co-operative	Nilgiris, Tamil Nadu	Sobha Madhan (Kurumba Adivasi, coordinator of NPVTG Federation); income from ₹200–300/kg → ₹1,000/kg through fair-value marketing
Piped Water Project	Surgana taluka, Nashik, Maharashtra	Universal household water access; significantly reduced women's workload and water-borne diseases

B. Social Interventions

Initiative	Location	Details
Sickle cell anaemia awareness camps	Madhya Pradesh	Early detection and prevention among Saharia and Bhil communities — high prevalence disease addressed
"Period Homes" initiative	Fasli Tola village, Gadchiroli, Maharashtra	Led by Sarpanch Tulavi ; modern spaces replacing unsafe <i>kurma huts</i> (isolation huts for menstruating women); menstrual health awareness

C. Human Rights Intervention

Bonded Labour Rescue — Sakleshpur, Hassan, Karnataka: Rescued **24 bonded labourers including 10 children** from a brick kiln. Workers trafficked from Krishnagiri (Tamil Nadu) — highlights inter-state trafficking of tribal labour.

D. Cultural Intervention — Revival of Tribal Theatre in Odisha

- Bhubaneswar-based NGO driving tribal theatre revival **since 1986**
- Trained over **500 tribal youth** from Rayagada, Keonjhar, Mayurbhanj, Kandhamal
- Staged **25 major plays** and **50+ cycle-theatre expeditions** village to village
- **Challenges:** Artists drop out due to poverty, migration, lack of institutional support

Conclusion on NGOs: Grassroots NGOs are crucial for economic security, healthcare, gender dignity, and human rights. Success depends on **local participation, institutional support, and a rights-based approach**. NGOs complement official programmes with a personal and culturally sensitive approach that government machinery often cannot provide.

UPSC Probable Q: "Discuss the role of NGOs in tribal development with specific case studies." | "What are the limitations of voluntary agencies in tribal welfare? How can they be addressed?" | "Examine the contribution of missionaries as the first voluntary agencies for tribal development."

9.2 — Role of Anthropology in Tribal and Rural Development

M.N. Srinivas (Simla Seminar, 1972): "I find today sharply increased awareness of the importance and urgency of associating sociologists and anthropologists in the solution of the many complex and baffling problems which confront the country today."

Why Anthropological Studies Help — Methodological Edge

Method	Contribution
Cultural Relativism	Neutral perspective without preconceived notions; objective work without ethnocentric bias
Field Work / Participant Observation	Insider perspective; become part of the society; authentic data
Holistic Studies	Every aspect analyzed from multiple dimensions simultaneously
Integrated Studies	Understand how economic, social, cultural elements are interconnected

Historical Marginalization of Anthropologists: Anthropologists' importance first recognised by **Court of Directors in 1807**. *Hutton, S.C. Roy, D.N. Majumdar, Elwin* highlighted negative impacts of contact — labelled "no changers," "revivalists," "isolationists." Post-independence: policies did not include anthropologists → benefits did not reach tribals → led to **Applied Anthropology**.

Applied Anthropology — "Anthropology put to use": Sometimes called the "*fifth sub-field*". Application of methods and theory to analysis and solution of **practical problems** in development, health, conflict resolution.

Key Anthropological Contributions to Tribal Development

1. Nature-Man-Spirit Complex (L.P. Vidyarthi): Helps understand equilibrium between ecology, social organization, and superhuman component. Helps plan tribal rehabilitation *with least resistance*. Essential for culturally sensitive development planning.

2. Tribe-Caste Continuum: Shows why it is difficult to define tribes with specific criteria. Demonstrates how tribal and non-tribal communities have influenced each other over centuries — basis for nuanced policy design.

3. Integrationist Approach (Verrier Elwin): 'A Philosophy for NEFA', 1957 (foreword by Nehru). Tribes not forced to give up tribal identity; choice left to tribals themselves. Became India's official tribal policy framework.

4. Development of PVTG Category (1973/2006): Anthropologists contributed through in-depth understanding of socio-economic marginalization, highlighting vulnerabilities, advocating for targeted policies. Dhebar Commission's work drew on anthropological studies.

5. Tribal Sub-Plan (TSP): Expert Committee under Ministry of Education and Social Welfare, **1972**. Adopted for first time in **Fifth Five-Year Plan**. Anthropologists highlighted socio-economic and cultural distinctiveness justifying dedicated plan resources.

6. Criminal Tribes Act Repeal & DNTs: CTA 1924 repealed by Criminal Tribes Laws (Repeal) Act, 1952. Anthropologists' role: provided understanding of history, culture, social dynamics; advocated DNTs as citizens with equal rights, not hereditary criminals.

7. Forest Rights — B.K. Roy Burman Committee on Forests and Tribals (1982):

Recognised traditional forest-dwelling communities had deep understanding of forests. Advocated *community-based forest management* and tribal rights over forest resources. Helped shape the landmark **Forest Rights Act of 2006**.

8. Xaxa Committee Report (2014) — Virginus Xaxa (TISS): High-level committee; submitted to PMO in **May 2014**. Six thematic issues: (1) Livelihoods and employment status; (2) Education; (3) Health; (4) Land alienation; (5) Displacement and enforced migration; (6) Legal/constitutional issues; delivery of public goods and services. *Key findings:* Rights of tribals to refuse land acquisition; empowerment of gram sabha and tribal advisory council; rights of tribes in Scheduled Areas to mine minerals. Emphasized tribal groups have fallen behind over last 60 years despite India's rapid expansion.

9. Development of Tribal Health: Expert Committee Report: "*Tribal Health in India — Bridging the Gap and a Roadmap for the Future*" (first of its kind). Recommendations: Annual budget equal to **2.5% GDP per capita** allocated for tribal healthcare (~INR 2500 per tribal in 2015–16); new entities: **Tribal Health Council** and **Directorate for Tribal Health** at state and union levels; government focus **70% of resources** on primary care; adequate human resources and infrastructure.

10. Safeguarding Endangered Languages: Linguistic research and documentation; raising awareness about language endangerment; advocating for language revitalization programs — Anthropologists central to Endangered Languages documentation projects.

Role of Anthropology in Rural Development

Historical Background of Village Studies

Scholar	Work	Contribution
Robert Redfield	Work in Mexico	Initiated field work in villages; developed Little and Great Traditions concept
William Wiser (1930s)	<i>Hindu Jajmani System; Behind the Mud Walls</i>	Pioneered rural India studies; documented Jajmani system
D.N. Majumdar	<i>Caste and Communication in an Indian Village</i>	Impact of transport/communication on caste mobility
S.C. Dube	<i>Indian Village</i>	Classic village study — social organisation, change

Oscar Lewis	Rural Cosmopolitanism	Rural India dynamics and change
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Key Theoretical Concepts from Village Studies

Concept	Scholar
Dominant Caste	M.N. Srinivas
Sanskritization and Westernization	M.N. Srinivas
Little Republics	Charles Metcalfe
Rural Cosmopolitanism	Oscar Lewis
Little and Great Traditions	Robert Redfield
Universalization and Parochialization	McKim Marriott
Sacred Complex	L.P. Vidyarthi
Nature-Man-Spirit Complex	L.P. Vidyarthi

Application in Rural Development

Issue	Anthropological Contribution
Agrarian Social Structure	Ethnographic works showed how land relations, caste hierarchy, and ritual power interact; inequality rooted in cultural values and kinship obligations; guided land reform, community development, Panchayati Raj policies
Left-Wing Extremism (Naxalism)	Micro-level accounts of deprivation among Santhal, Munda, Gond; helped shape PESA (1996) and FRA (2006); where political science saw rebellion, anthropology saw <i>cultural resistance</i>
Regionalism	Demonstrated regional movements arise from cultural neglect and symbolic exclusion; Vidyarthi showed sacred centres like Gaya unite diverse groups through rituals; studies in Jharkhand and Northeast revealed folk culture/language ignoring leads to identity mobilization

Conclusion: Fieldwork tradition helped locate **channels of social change**. Helped understand role of communication in breakdown of caste prejudices and emerging power structures. Applied Anthropology: participatory research methods, evidence-based recommendations. Contribution acknowledged by global institutions including **World Bank**.

UPSC Probable Q: "How has anthropology contributed to the formulation of tribal development policies in India?" | "Discuss the contributions of applied anthropology to rural development." | "Examine the role of key scholars in shaping India's tribal policy through anthropological research."

9.3 — Communalism

Definition: "An ideology based on the belief that society is divided into religious communities whose interests differ and are opposed to each other and hence antagonistic in nature" (1979). Antagonism practiced by people of one community against people of another community and religion.

Factors Responsible for Communalism

1. Divisive Politics: Religion or cultural identity used to mobilize support; "majority-minority divide" consolidated for votes. Weakens secular democracy.

2. Politics of Appeasement — Shah Bano Case (1985–86):

- Supreme Court upheld Shah Bano's right to post-divorce maintenance under secular law
- **Rajiv Gandhi government** reversed verdict through **Muslim Women (Protection of Rights on Divorce) Act, 1986**
- Textbook case of *vote-bank politics and state surrender to religious orthodoxy*

3. Shift to Religious Mobilisation:

- **Rath Yatra (1990):** Large religious procession from Gujarat to Ayodhya
- **By 1992:** Demolition of Babri Masjid — violence erupted from both sides
- Reflected fragility of communal balance

4. Economic Causes:

- **UN MPI (2023):** One in three Muslims in India is multidimensionally poor
- Economic competition between Hindu and Muslim traders adds to distrust
- Continued reliance on outdated madrasa education

5. Historical and Structural Factors: Communal tensions reappear in places with past history of conflict. Delays in justice or administrative gaps allow small disputes to grow into full-scale riots.

6. Psychological and Social Dimensions: Sustained by *social distance and fear*; arises from misunderstanding, lack of communication. **Karnataka Anti-Conversion Bill (2021):** Christian community protests reflected perception/communication gaps.

7. Role of Media and Social Media:

- Sensationalist coverage inflames tensions
- **Delhi Riots (2020):** Viral videos used to spread anger and misinformation
- Social media *nationalises local conflicts* into pan-India communal narratives

8. Communal Violence and Civic Ties — Ashutosh Varshney (2002): Shared civic associations and neighbourhood networks reduce communal violence. Where Hindus and Muslims participate in same trade unions, sport clubs, civic organisations — riots less likely. *The Civic Life Argument:* **Saumitra Jha** found Gujarat's medieval port towns with historic Hindu-Muslim trade ties were **25% less likely** to experience riots in 2002.

Instances of Communal Violence

Event	Year	Details
Partition Riots	1947	~15 million displaced; close to 1 million lives lost; trauma of divided homeland — worst communal violence in modern India
Anti-Sikh Riots	1984	After assassination of PM Indira Gandhi; thousands of Sikhs killed; gurdwaras destroyed
Gujarat Riots	2002	Sabarmati Express attacked at Godhra (59 Hindu pilgrims killed) → retaliatory violence across state
Kandhamal Violence	2008, Odisha	After killing of Swami Laxmanananda Saraswati; Maoists claimed responsibility but Christian communities attacked

Features of Communal Riots (Probe of Last 5 Decades)

- More **politically motivated than fuelled by religion**
- Besides political interests, **economic interests** play a vigorous part
- More common in **North India** than South and East
- **Possibility of recurrence is stronger** in towns where riots have already occurred

- Most take place during **religious festivals**
- Use of **deadly weapons** is on the ascendancy

Overall Assessment — India's Resilience:

- India: 1.4 billion people of diverse faiths; **99%** coexist harmoniously every day
- India's civilisational philosophy of tolerance reflected in Vedas, Upanishads, Buddha, Mahavira, Sufis, Bhakti saints
- These incidents are *exceptions rather than the rule*

Concluding Philosophy on Communalism

India: land of rich diversities — *"We're all minorities in India"*

"Acceptance of difference rather than mere tolerance" — the great Indian secret

Rig Veda: *"Ekam Sat Vipra bahudha vadanti"* — "There is only one truth and learned persons call it by many names"

UPSC Probable Q: "Critically examine the factors responsible for communalism in India with reference to specific instances." | "Discuss Ashutosh Varshney's argument on civic ties as a solution to communal violence." | "How does economic inequality contribute to communalism? Examine with data." | "Is communalism a political or a religious phenomenon? Critically analyse."

Quick Revision — All Scholars at a Glance

Scholar	Key Contribution / Concept	Topic
N.K. Bose	Peasantization; Tribe-Caste Continuum; Tribe-Rajput Continuum	Hinduism Impact
M.N. Srinivas	Sanskritization (1952); Dominant Caste; missionaries as "bait in trap"	Social Change
C. von Furer-Haimendorf (1983)	Buddhist converts in Arunachal retained tribal rituals — symbiosis	Buddhism Impact
Verrier Elwin	Isolationist (1939, 'The Baiga'); Integrationist (1957, 'NEFA Philosophy')	Approaches

G.S. Ghurye	Tribes as "backward Hindus"; Assimilationist approach	Approaches
Jawaharlal Nehru	Tribal Panchsheel (1957); foreword to 'NEFA Philosophy'	Tribal Policy
L.P. Vidyarthi	Nature-Man-Spirit Complex; Sacred Complex; Sacred Geography	Anthropology in Dev.
Virginus Xaxa	Xaxa Committee Report (2014) — 6 thematic issues for tribal welfare	Tribal Policy
B.K. Roy Burman	Committee on Forests and Tribals (1982); shaped FRA 2006	Forest Rights
Ashutosh Varshney (2002)	Civic ties reduce communal violence	Communalism
Saumitra Jha	Gujarat port towns 25% less likely to riot — historical trade ties	Communalism
Robert Redfield	Little and Great Traditions; initiated village field work	Rural Dev.
William Wiser	Hindu Jajmani System; Behind the Mud Walls	Rural Dev.
Oscar Lewis	Rural Cosmopolitanism	Rural Dev.
McKim Marriott	Universalization and Parochialization	Rural Dev.
Charles Metcalfe	Little Republics (village self-sufficiency)	Rural Dev.
A.V. Thakkar (Thakkar Bapa)	Bhil Seva Mandal; 21 tribal welfare institutions	NGOs
S.C. Dube	Indian Village — classic ethnography	Rural Dev.
D.N. Majumdar	Caste and Communication in an Indian Village	Rural Dev.

UPSC Master Question Bank — This Topic

1. Critically examine the impact of Hinduism on tribal societies with reference to the Tribe-Caste Continuum and Sanskritization. (15 marks)
2. Assess the role of Christian missionaries in tribal development with specific reference to Northeast India. (15 marks)
3. Compare the impact of Buddhism and Christianity on tribal societies in India. (10 marks)
4. Examine the Taravad system of Lakshadweep and how Islam has impacted the matrilineal system there. (10 marks)
5. How do tribal identities come into conflict with the nation-state's demand for uniform citizenship? (10 marks)
6. Compare isolationist, assimilationist, and integrationist approaches to tribal development. Which is most suitable for India and why? (20 marks)
7. What is Tribal Panchsheel? Critically evaluate its implementation. (10 marks)
8. What are PVTGs? Discuss their criteria, challenges, and government schemes. (15 marks)
9. Discuss the historical origins and present-day challenges of Denotified Tribes (DNTs) in India. (15 marks)
10. Discuss the role of NGOs in tribal development with specific case studies. (15 marks)
11. How has anthropology contributed to the formulation of tribal development policies in India? (15 marks)
12. Examine the Xaxa Committee Report (2014) and its significance for tribal welfare. (10 marks)
13. Critically examine the factors responsible for communalism in India. (15 marks)
14. Discuss Ashutosh Varshney's argument on civic ties as a solution to communal violence. (10 marks)